Calvin Clack

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Education

University of Illinois Chicago 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. Candidate, Economics. GPA: 3.82

CFA Institute 2025
CFA Level III, Completed

University of Chicago 2024
Ph.D. Exchange Scholar, Economics. GPA: 3.80

DePaul University 2020
M.S., Finance. GPA: 3.87

Purdue University 2017
B.S., Mechanical Engineering. GPA: 3.21

Research Fields

Macroeconomics and Monetary Economics; Life Cycle Models and Saving, Unemployment Rate, and Precautionary Saving

Dissertation

Employment Status and Credit Cycles: An Extensive Margin Analysis in Heterogeneous Agent Life Cycle Models

Abstract: This paper addresses a critical gap between structural modeling conventions and empirical evidence regarding labor market adjustment margins. While most structural models emphasize the intensive margin (hours worked per agent), empirical evidence underscores the extensive margin (employment status), which remains overlooked even in models with incomplete markets. This discrepancy is addressed here through two frameworks: a three period Overlapping Generations (OLG) model with varying youth unemployment and a Heterogeneous Agent (HA) Life cycle framework, featuring age dependent unemployment distributions and precautionary savings motivations with exogenous labor productivity shocks. Comparative statics in the OLG model demonstrate that variations in the extensive margin substantially reshape credit markets by lowering household debt levels and real interest rates. Within the HA model, real household debt drops by roughly 3.3% per 1 pp increase in unemployment and exhibits two key mechanisms: decreased loan demand from young unemployed agents facing borrowing constraints and increased supply from households self insuring against elevated unemployment risk through precautionary savings. Impulse response analysis reveals that negative productivity shocks induce sharper household deleveraging when labor changes through the extensive margin. The theoretical implications are empirically corroborated using both Vector Autoregression and Local Projection methods on European data from 1998 to 2019 and US data from 1952 to 2019. These results matter because higher unemployment forces borrowing constrained households to deleverage, which depresses real interest rates toward the zero lower bound and reduces utility. The findings point to income insurance and automatic stabilizers as a direct way to mitigate the cost of unemployment.

Presentations

University of Illinois Chicago, Economics Department Seminar — Fall 2026
University of Illinois Chicago, Economics Active Research Lunch — Fall 2025 and Spring 2026
Illinois Economic Association Annual Meeting — Fall 2025

Teaching Experience

University of Illinois Chicago — Chicago, IL

Instructor

- ECON 121 – Principles of Macroeconomics — Fall 2025, Spring 2026
- ECON 221 – Macroeconomics in the World Economy — Summer 2024, Fall 2024, Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant

- ECON 512 – Macroeconomic Theory II — Fall 2026
- ECON 221 – Macroeconomics in the World Economy — Fall 2023, Fall 2026
- ECON 120 – Principles of Microeconomics — Spring 2023, Spring 2024
- ECON 121 – Principles of Macroeconomics — Fall 2022

Fields of Teaching Competence

Economics

- Principles of Macroeconomics, Intermediate Macroeconomics, Advanced Macroeconomics, Computational Methods (Macroeconomics), Principles of Microeconomics

Business

- Corporate Finance, Investments, Financial Accounting, Quantitative Methods

Technical Skills

Programming: Python, MATLAB, R, Microsoft Office (VBA), Local AI Integration

Modeling: Dynamic Programming, Econometric Modeling, Finite Difference Methods, Heterogeneous Agent Macroeconomic Modeling, Machine Learning, Quasi-Newton Methods, Time Series Analysis

Finance: DCF Modeling, Financial Statement Analysis, Portfolio Theory, Monte Carlo Simulation, Scenario Analysis, VaR

Professional Memberships

CFA Institute (Associate Member); CFA Society Chicago (Candidate Member)

References

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